UX Research Artifacts

(Be Minimalist)

UX / HCI Research Study — D2C Skincare E-commerce

Field Details

Field	Details
Student Name	Kshitij Garg
PRN	1032230606
Websites Analysed	Be Minimalist
Websites	https://beminimalist.co/
Design Concept	Be Minimalist UI redesign concept (home, catalog, product, and cart screens)

Empathy Map → Pain Points → Persona → User Journey Map → Gaps for Improvement → Wireframe Concept

Introduction

This assignment presents a UX research artifact set for **Be Minimalist**, an Indian direct-to-consumer skincare brand known for active-ingredient products like Niacinamide, Salicylic Acid, and Vitamin C. It follows the standard UX research structure: Empathy Map, Pain Points, Persona, User Journey Map, and Gaps for Improvement, followed by the wireframe direction derived from the findings.

The store has a clean, clinical laboratory look and transparent pricing, but buying chemical skincare online can be intimidating for normal users. Shoppers worry about picking the wrong chemical percentage or accidentally mixing conflicting ingredients that might irritate their skin. The research follows one representative shopper to understand what makes her journey hesitant and how the interface can be improved.

Research Context

- **Journey studied (Ananya Sharma):** Land on home → browse and search by concern → compare serums → evaluate routine compatibility → add to cart and checkout.
- The UI screens in Section 6 show a redesign concept responding to the issues found in Assignment 1.
- The research focuses on usability, clarity of active ingredients, error prevention (routine conflicts), and shopping efficiency.

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1. Empathy Map

The empathy map represents a typical shopper on the platform who wants effective skincare but is unsure about chemical compatibility.

1.1 Be Minimalist — Ananya Sharma

Empathy Area	User Insight
SAYS	“Which serum is actually right for my acne marks?”“What percentage should a beginner like me start with?”“Why do all these amber bottles look almost identical?”“Can I use Salicylic Acid and Retinol together?”
THINKS	“Will mixing two active serums irritate my skin barrier?”“Is 10% Niacinamide too strong, or should I start with 5%?”“Why is the dropdown menu so crowded on my phone?”“I hope I don’t buy the wrong product and have to return it.”
DOES	Searches for everyday skin symptoms like “acne marks” in the search bar.Scrolls past promotional banners to find product details.Opens multiple tabs to compare different serum ingredients.Checks review counts, star ratings, and prices on product cards.
FEELS	Interested in the science-backed, honest branding and fair prices.Overwhelmed by dense chemical names and percentages.Worried about causing skin breakouts from incompatible products.Reassured by visible review ratings and clear pricing.

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2. Pain Points

The following pain points consolidate the findings from the empathy map and heuristic review:

#	Pain Point	Observed / User Impact	Priority
1	**No ingredient conflict warnings**	Users can add conflicting actives (like Retinol and peeling acids) to the cart without any warning about skin irritation.	High
2	**Identical product appearance**	All serum bottles use similar amber glass packaging, making it hard to tell products apart quickly in the grid.	High
3	**Chemical jargon for beginners**	Naming products strictly after chemical percentages confuses first-time buyers seeking solutions for acne or dark spots.	High
4	**No side-by-side comparison**	Users evaluating two strengths of the same active (like Niacinamide 10% vs 5%) have to open multiple tabs to compare them.	High
5	**Popup widget clutter**	Floating chat badges and discount popups crowd the bottom corner of mobile screens.	Medium
6	**Dense dropdown menu**	The navigation menu lists over 40 links in multiple columns, which feels crowded.	Medium

3. Persona

To ground the research in realistic user needs, the persona below represents a typical young working professional seeking clinical skincare:

3.1 Be Minimalist — Ananya Sharma

Persona Attribute	Description
Name / Age	Ananya Sharma, 24
Education	B.Tech (Computer Science)
Hometown	Bangalore

Persona Attribute	Description
Occupation	Junior Marketing Associate
Quote	*“I want science-backed skincare that actually works on my acne without guessing which chemicals are safe to use together.”*
Primary Goal	Find the right active serums for acne marks, verify ingredient safety, and buy with confidence.

- **Background:** Ananya spends long hours in front of screens and recently started getting adult acne and dark spots. Tired of fragranced cosmetics with false promises, she wants clean, science-backed skincare. She likes Be Minimalist’s pricing, but feels nervous about choosing chemical actives without guidance.
- **Goals:** Clear up acne safely, find the right percentage strength, and ensure selected serums can be layered together.
- **Frustrations:** Identical-looking amber bottles, chemical jargon without plain explanations, and fear of damaging her skin barrier.
- **Key Needs:** A quick beginner quiz, visual category tags on cards, and a routine compatibility check before checkout.

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4. User Journey Map

Goal: Find the right skincare actives for acne, ensure they are safe to use together, and purchase with confidence.

Stage	Actions	Thoughts	Pain Points	Opportunities
1. Land on Home	Opens site, scrolls past hero offers, looks for acne products.	*“Where do I start if I don’t know the exact chemical name?”*	Promo banners push discounts instead of helping choose products.	Add a prominent 30-second skin quiz button on the hero section.
2. Browse & Search	Types “acne” in search bar, opens the Acne Concern collection.	*“All these amber bottles look the same —which one is for active pimples?”*	Identical product photos make browsing slow.	Add small color tags (e.g. Amber for Exfoliation, Blue for Hydration).

Stage	Actions	Thoughts	Pain Points	Opportunities
3. Compare & Choose	Opens Salicylic Acid 2% and Niacinamide 10% pages, reads benefits.	*"Can I apply both of these on the same night?"*	Full ingredient list is hard to read; no side-by-side comparison.	Add a "Decoded Ingredients" table and a side-by-side comparison drawer.
4. Add to Cart & Safety	Adds both serums to cart, checks total and shipping threshold.	*"Are these two safe to layer together, or will they irritate my skin?"*	Cart does not warn about active ingredient compatibility.	Add a Routine Compatibility note in the cart confirming safe layering.
5. Checkout	Enters phone number, verifies OTP on Gokwik, pays via UPI.	*"Quick and simple checkout!"*	Corner popup widgets can crowd the mobile screen.	Keep bottom screen clean and show on-site order tracking.

5. Gaps for Improvement

Based on the research findings, the key areas for improvement are:

1. **Automated routine compatibility check:** Show a note in the cart confirming whether chosen actives can be used together safely.
2. **Visual category tags on cards:** Add subtle color tags to distinguish between exfoliating, hydrating, and soothing serums.
3. **30-second skin diagnostic quiz:** Guide beginners from everyday concerns (acne, redness) to a simple 3-step routine.
4. **Side-by-side comparison drawer:** Let users compare active concentrations, pH levels, and skin suitability across serums.
5. **Decoded ingredients breakdown:** Replace dense paragraphs of Latin chemical names with clean, readable bullet points.
6. **Clean mobile layout:** Combine floating corner support and reward widgets into a single compact icon.

6. Wireframe Direction Derived from the Research

The research findings were translated into a UI redesign concept across 4 core screens:

- **Screen 1: Home screen** (with 30-second skin quiz hero, concern selector chips, and color-tagged bestsellers).
- **Screen 2: Catalog screen** (with concern and strength filters, plus a side-by-side comparison drawer).
- **Screen 3: Product detail page** (with decoded ingredient table, routine step badge, and layering compatibility guide).
- **Screen 4: Cart drawer** (with automated routine compatibility check, free gift progress bar, and Gokwik 1-click checkout).

Research Findings Mapped to the Wireframe

Research Finding	Wireframe Response
Users worry about mixing conflicting actives	The cart drawer displays an automated **Routine Compatibility Note** confirming safe usage or suggesting alternate nights.
Identical amber bottles confuse shoppers	Product cards include a subtle **Category Tag** (e.g. [Exfoliant / BHA], [Sebum Control]) with distinct accent colors.
Beginners struggle with chemical jargon	The hero banner features a **"Take 30-Sec Skin Diagnostic"** button that maps skin concerns to simple 3-step routines.
Hard to compare two similar serums	A **Compare Drawer** lets users select 2 serums and view their concentrations, pH, and skin suitability side by side.
Dense chemical ingredient lists	Product pages feature a **Decoded INCI Table** explaining each ingredient's origin, role, and safety rating.
Popup widgets crowd mobile screens	Support and reward widgets are tucked into a single compact button to keep the screen uncluttered.

Conclusion

Be Minimalist has a credible, well-trusted store with transparent formulations and fair pricing. However, the research shows that shopping for active chemical skincare creates hesitation when users are left to figure out ingredient compatibility on their own.

The proposed improvements focus on adding a simple skin diagnostic quiz, visual category tags on product cards, a side-by-side comparison view, and a routine compatibility check in the cart. These additions make the shopping experience safer, calmer, and much easier for everyday buyers while preserving the brand’s clean, minimalist identity.

Source / Basis of Analysis

The research is based on the student’s empathy map, persona, and user journey map for `beminimalist.co`, the heuristic evaluation in Assignment 1, and benchmark analysis of clinical skincare e-commerce sites. The persona is a plausible composite created for UX analysis.